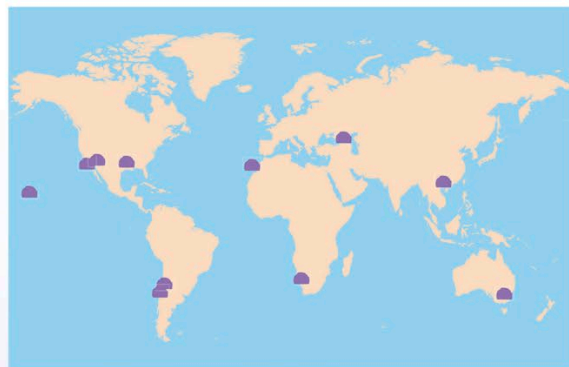


Observatories

Light is constantly reaching us from space, and one way astronomers learn about space is by studying this light. To do this effectively, an astronomer needs a telescope and a clear night sky.



The world's major observatories are all on extinct volcanoes or high mountains, as this is where the air is clearest.



Island observatory

Two of the world's largest light-detecting telescopes are the twin Keck telescopes. These are on the summit of Mauna Kea, a dormant (sleeping) volcano in Hawaii. The summit is clear of light and dust pollution. They both contain mirrors that are 10 m (33 ft) across.



Twin Keck telescopes